

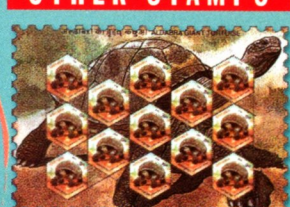
Commemorative stamps find their way to collectors even before they are officially released. Dealers charge a hefty premium, but it is a small price to pay for exclusivity, even as the trade is illegal.



UNRELEASED

Indian Coast Guard
 Seller: Stamp4evr, India
 Date of sale: May 20, '08
 Date of release: Unreleased
 Actual price: Rs 20
 Sold for: Rs 869

OTHER STAMPS



Name of the stamp: Aldabra Giant Turtles
 Seller: Stamp4evr, India
 Date of sale: March 22, '08
 Date of release: August 2, '08
 Actual price: Rs 260
 Sold for: Rs 940



Name of the stamp: Jasmine
 Seller: Fdc4u, Pakistan
 Date of sale: February 28, '08
 Date of release: April 26, '08
 Actual price: Rs 20
 Sold for: Rs 186

PHILATELY WEBSITES FROM INDIA AND ABROAD, INCLUDING PAKISTAN.

the Philatelic Deposit Account Scheme. They are printed one time only and therefore are available in limited quantities and are much sought after. Definitive stamps are used for postal purposes. They are available in all the post offices and reprinted many times. "Authorised offices only sell commemorative/special stamps, blank first day covers and brochures," says the government philately website.

The sale and purchase of philately items, like artefacts, is pursued as a full time vocation by dealers because big money is involved. There is a huge demand for philately items the world over, and it has grown substantially after on-line trading on portals like delcampe.net and ebay was introduced. In India, the quantum of trade in stamps has risen exponentially in the last couple of years;

online trading linking them to some five million philately collectors worldwide. There is a lot of money involved in the release of pre-issue stamps, as they are exclusively available with a particular dealer and his monopoly allows him to charge any price he wants.

There is a clear trend seen here. From pre-issue sales of Jasmine stamp to Indian Coast Guard stamp, profit margins have become substantially larger. In the case of Jasmine stamp, the sale premium was only four times vis-a-vis the actual price, but in the case of the Indian Coast Guard stamp, it rose to 40 times. The popular categories are flora and fauna, wildlife, flowers and defence. INDIA TODAY's enquiries reveal disturbing facts about these leakages. The stamps are pilfered in bulk quantities by people working in the postal de-

partment and are sold by dealers here or in foreign countries before they are officially available.

The scam is fuelled by the fact that stamps are sent to the bureaux months in advance of their official release, which encourages the illicit trade. There is meant to be periodic checks but these are few and far between and rarely detect any missing items. Genuine dealers allege most leakages happen in Delhi. Officials in the department refuse to speak on the issue. Deputy Director-General (DDG)-Philately R.R.P. Singh, who is preparing to host a philately outlet in Olympics in Beijing, said, "I am not authorised to speak on this issue." Secretary Post Radhika Doraiswamy did not agree to a meeting, while the other top official in the department, Special Secretary Operations Meera Datta, refused to take any calls. Finally, Minister of State Jyotiraditya Scindia was contacted, and he said: "I will respond once I have the details." The details of misuse of postal property were mailed to him.

On Scindia's intervention, the DDG agreed to talk to INDIA TODAY. Explaining the possible points of leakages, he said the stamps are printed at the Indian Press, Nasik, from where they are sent to the philately bureaux. Stamps remain lodged with them for months because their date of release keeps changing depending on the availability of VIPs to release them. Singh concedes that in light of the damaging evidence obtained by INDIA TODAY, pilferage could be happening at the bureau level due to the nexus between "unscrupulous dealers" and "some postal employees".

He asserted that even "holding" (let alone trading) of stamps before their release is a criminal offence, and acknowledged that his department was not able to detect pilferage during the periodic stock inspections. "We are immediately releasing the Indian Coast Guard stamp on the 12th (August). The postmaster general is asked to carry out an enquiry to get to the root of the matter. And as a policy, now stamps will be sent from Nasik to bureaux only a couple of days before release. Those found guilty will be dealt with severely." Now that Scindia is aware, he will hopefully be in a position to stamp out the scam. ■